

THE ART OF THE DRY FLY

1-Day Intensive · Student Handout · Condensed from the 2-Day Program

© Mac Brown Fly Fish · © Fly Fishing Guide School · Bryson City, NC | macbrownflyfish.com · flyfishingguideschool.com

8 hrs 7:30 AM–4:00 PM	~5 hrs ON-WATER TIME	8 SESSIONS	7 SKILL PILLARS COVERED
---------------------------------	--------------------------------	----------------------	--------------------------------------

Leader Building · Presentation Casting · Active & Passive Floats · Mending · Rise Forms · Fly Selection · Stealth & Approach

Resources: Leader Construction · Fly Casting Terms & Definitions · Fly Fishing Terms & Definitions

QUICK REFERENCE — RISE FORMS AT A GLANCE

RISE	WHAT IT MEANS / HOW TO RESPOND
Sip	Gentle ring, nose through film — dun or spinner. Dead drift essential.
Slash	Aggressive take — caddis escaping. React quickly; skitter or twitch.
Porpoise Roll	Dorsal-then-tail, no nose — emerger subsurface. Try cripple or soft-hackle.
Boil / Bulge	Hump with no surface break — nymph. Not a dry fly moment.
Spotted Ring	Circular ring with bubbles — spinner in film. Match film pattern.
Compound Rise	Fish drifts under fly and inspects — fix drift before changing fly.

FLOAT STYLES

STYLE	EXECUTION & USE
Dead Drift	Fly leads all line — no drag. Duns, spinners, trapped emergers.
Twitch	1-inch rod-tip hammer. Caddis and stonefly trigger.
Skitter	3–4 fast rod pulses cross-current. Caddis behavior.
Skate	Sustained rod-high movement. Pool tails and smooth slicks. No V-wake.

FLY STYLE BY WATER TYPE

WATER TYPE	RECOMMENDED STYLE & PATTERNS
Pocket Water & Riffles	High-floating attractors: Royal Wulff, Stimulator, Humpy, Elk Hair Caddis
Run Seams	Convertible: Parachute Adams, Klinkhämer, Convertible Caddis

WATER TYPE	RECOMMENDED STYLE & PATTERNS
Glassy Flats & Pools	Precise imitations: CDC Dun, Sparkle Dun, Comparadun, Griffith's Gnat
Pool Tails	Low-riding emergers & cripples: CDC Emerger, RS2, Barr Emerger

REFUSAL RESPONSE — FIX DRIFT BEFORE CHANGING FLY

#	ACTION	WHY
1	Adjust Drift	Lengthen tippet, change angle, add aerial mend
2	Extend Tippet	12–18" of finer tippet — more S-curve, less shadow
3	Downsize Fly	Drop one or two hook sizes
4	Change Stage	Emerger → dun → spinner or vice versa
5	Change Pattern	Last resort — stage, size, and drift must be right first

1-Day Intensive — Art of the Dry Fly

7:30 – 8:15 am Philosophy, observation & leader building

LEADER + PHILOSOPHY

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the arc of this day and the instructor approach: observation before presentation
- Build a tapered leader from component spools
- Match tippet size to fly size
- Test leader turnover before going to the water

KEY CONCEPTS

Tapered leader: butt 60%, mid 25%, tippet 15% · Diameter and stiffness control turnover, not breaking strength · Nylon monofilament only for dry flies — never fluorocarbon · 4X–7X tippet for flies #10–#22 · Blood knot for butt sections; surgeon's knot for tippet

Full leader-building breakdown: macbrownflyfish.com/blog/learn-leader-construction

ACTIVITIES

- Brief history: the lineage of dry fly thinking — why this skill is being lost
- Bench build: students build a 9–10 ft tapered leader from component spools
- Flat-water turnover test — does it unfurl cleanly into a soft pile?

“A leader can't fix what the cast doesn't do. Turnover and drag matter, but they don't replace the skill — the casting has to be there first, every time.”

Checkpoint: Each student's leader must demonstrate controlled turnover before advancing to the stream.

8:15 – 8:30 am · Walk to water

8:30 – 10:00 am Casting for better drifts — aerial mends & presentation CASTING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute reach cast, pile cast, and at least one curve cast
- Understand why aerial mends outperform post-landing mends for dry flies
- Apply a single-handed Spey for direction changes in tight cover
- Throw an S-curve wiggle cast for complex multi-current situations

KEY CONCEPTS

Reach cast: rod tip swings upstream during forward cast · Pile/puddle cast: controlled collapse for instant slack · Curve cast: banking around obstacles · S-curve wiggle cast: rod-tip oscillation during delivery · Single-handed Spey: snap-T for direction changes · Upstream vs. downstream cast geometry

ACTIVITIES

- Flat-water drill: reach, pile, curve left, curve right — 6 reps each
- Moving-water seam drill: which cast solves this current situation?
- Spey practice: one direction-change scenario in streamside brush

“To do this in its purest form means mastering curve and pile casts for all casting planes. Change-of-direction casts matched to dynamic currents where trout actually hold — this is where the art lives.”

Checkpoint: Each student completes: reach cast across a seam, pile cast to a pool, and one direction-change Spey. Instructor assesses whether tippet leads or lags the fly.

10:00 – 11:00 am Active vs. passive floats — and rise form reading FLOAT + RISE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Distinguish when a dead drift serves vs. when movement triggers strikes
- Execute a twitch and skitter without creating a V-wake
- Identify sip, slash, porpoise, boil, and spotted-ring rises from the bank
- Diagnose feeding stage from rise form before selecting a fly

KEY CONCEPTS

Dead drift: fly leads all line — no drag · Twitch: 1-inch rod-tip hammer for caddis and stonefly · Skitter: 3–4 fast pulses cross-current · Skate: sustained rod-high movement — pool tails only · V-wake: the drag signature that kills a presentation · Sip, slash, porpoise roll, boil, spotted ring — what each means

ACTIVITIES

- Calm eddy: twitch and skitter drill — partner enforces no V-wake rule
- Pool tail skate: caddis pattern, no V-wake, dead drift to skitter transition
- Bankside observation: 15-minute watch-only exercise — students call rise type and suspected food

“I am not advocating always fishing dries — but fly fishers should become adept at perfecting their dry fly game for a richer experience overall.”

Checkpoint: Each student correctly identifies passive or active float for two water types and calls at least 4 rise forms correctly from live observation.

11:00 – 11:45 am · Lunch — students draw intended afternoon water and note likely rise forms

11:45 am – 1:00 pm Mending for enticement — line control beyond the dead drift

MENDING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute upstream and reach mend without disturbing the fly
- Use S-curve and belly to buy extra drift time across a current seam
- Apply a downstream slack-line presentation for fish above your position
- Understand when mending ends and intentional skating begins

KEY CONCEPTS

Upstream mend: flip belly upstream — slows fly in fast current · Reach mend: done in the air — the dry fly ideal · Pile mend: slack dump on target for maximum initial drift · Downstream presentation: fly arrives before tippet on glassy water · Mend timing: earlier and farther than instinct suggests

ACTIVITIES

- Seam drill: achieve a 12-second drift across a current seam — with and without aerial mend
- Downstream presentation to a flat-pool fish: slack-line cast from above
- Partner feedback: call the first moment of drag onset

“The mend is your insurance — but the aerial cast is your best weapon. Most anglers mend too late and too close. Think of it as casting placement, not correction.”

Checkpoint: Each student achieves a minimum 10-second drag-free drift across a seam using an aerial mend and one post-landing correction. Instructor times.

1:00 – 2:00 pm Fly selection by water type & the complete presentation sequence

FLY + APPROACH

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Match fly style to water type using attractor-to-imitation spectrum

- Apply silhouette-first, size-second, color-last selection hierarchy
- Approach a rising fish without detection
- Execute the full sequence: observe → position → select → cast → drift → respond

KEY CONCEPTS

Pocket water: attractor · Seams: convertible · Flat pools: precise imitation · Pool tails: emerger/cripple · Approach from below and to the side — never upstream of a sighted fish · First cast is the best cast — plan it, don't rush it · Refusal: fix drift before changing fly · Patience: 10–15 minutes for fish to reset after disturbance

ACTIVITIES

- Fly box sort: organize by water type, not hatch — justify each choice to instructor
- Stalking exercise: approach a visible rising fish using heron-walk technique
- Full sequence rotation: locate, observe, position, select, cast, drift — one fish per student with coaching
- Refusal drill: diagnose and adjust before recasting

“We offer private wade trips for learning this on the stream — no doubt one of the quickest methods for improvement. The observation piece is what most people skip. The best cast you will ever make is the one you waited to throw.”

Checkpoint: Each student completes a full presentation sequence on a rising fish. Instructor grades stealth, fly selection logic, cast execution, and drift quality.

2:00 – 3:00 pm On-water practice — independent rising fish

APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply all day's skills on independent rising fish without direct coaching
- Self-diagnose refusals and adjust without instructor prompt
- Practice patient observation before every cast
- Build personal awareness of what each drift actually looks like

ACTIVITIES

- Each student is assigned an independent stretch with at least one rising fish
- Instructor observes from distance — notes for final debrief only, no real-time coaching
- After each fish attempt, student self-reports: rise form called, fly chosen, reason for refusal if it occurred

Checkpoint: This session is uncoached by design — the student must own the sequence. Instructor debrief at the end covers the most common self-reported errors.

3:00 – 4:00 pm Final debrief, written feedback & next steps

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Synthesize the day's arc from leader to live fish
- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one technical and one observational priority
- Build a personal 30-day practice plan

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment: leader turnover, aerial mend, float control, rise reading, fly selection, approach
- Individual feedback: one strength, one priority, one thing to practice on every outing
- Personal 30-day plan: specific water, specific skill, observation journal prompt

Checkpoint: Completed assessment returned to each student. Instructor retains copy for program records.